

Looking after your pads

Treasured Vessels Girls' Centre, Jinja · keep this with your kit

- 1 **Rinse in cold water** as soon as you can. Not hot: hot water sets the stain for good.
- 2 **Wash with soap** and warm water. Water on its own is not enough.
- 3 **Rinse until the water runs clear.** Soap left in the cloth stops it absorbing and irritates skin.
- 4 **Dry it completely**, in the sun if you can. Never put a damp pad away.
- 5 **Iron it** if you have an iron.
- 6 **Store it clean and dry**, in its own bag.

Get a new one when the cloth goes thin, the layers come apart, the stud stops holding, or it will not dry properly. Come and see us:
treasuredvesselsug@gmail.com · +256 756 233 041

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Before you hand out a kit

For whoever is doing the distribution

Treasured Vessels Girls' Centre

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SIX CONDITIONS. CHECK THEM WITH HER, NOT ABOUT HER.

- ☐ **She chose it.** Offered the option, shown how it works, and able to say no without awkwardness.
- ☐ **Enough pads in the set.** One pad cannot be washed, dried and worn at the same time.
- ☐ **Water and soap she can actually reach,** at the place and time she needs to wash.
- ☐ **Somewhere private to dry,** fully. The condition most often missing, and the one that decides everything.
- ☐ **Somewhere clean and dry to store them,** in a bag of their own.
- ☐ **She can change her mind** and get disposables, with no discussion about what the kit cost.

IF THE ANSWER TO ANY OF THESE IS NO

Give her disposables instead. A reusable kit without water, privacy or drying space is not a cheaper option for her. It is a daily problem she did not have before, and she will stop using it without telling you.

WHY THE WASHING METHOD MATTERS

Pads cleaned with **water only** carried the highest microbial loads in published testing. Pads cleaned with a combination of **detergent, disinfectant and ironing** showed minimal to no contamination.

So step two on the card is not housekeeping advice. It is the safety margin, and it is worth taking two minutes to say out loud rather than assuming she has read it.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE DOES AND DOES NOT SHOW

A Ugandan trial reported leakage among **44.4%** of reusable pad users against **78%** of girls using cloths, and girls rated the reusable pads as more reliable and easier to change. The same evaluation found **no significant difference** in outer-garment soiling or odour. Reviews of the African evidence note **no objective reporting on infection** either way. Say all of that, not only the first sentence.